

Discipline Yourself So No One Else Has To: Wrap-up, Featuring Joan Cronan

Joan Cronan, Women's Athletic Director Emeritus, University of Tennessee

I heard Pat say many, many times, “The most difficult part of self-discipline is convincing yourself that it’s in your own best interest. Being disciplined doesn’t always feel good. In fact, it can feel awful.”

She also wrote, “It makes your knees hurt and your ego suffer. It’s easy to say to yourself, ‘I really should take a break, give myself a rest.’ Self-discipline is not the path to instant gratification. The reward is much further down the road and not always obvious. But in the end, it is a much deeper form of gratification. The real reward is self-respect and long-term success.”

Pat’s key takeaways from this module are discipline must be fair, firm, and consistent. Being fair means there is no playing favorites, and the rules are in place to avoid problems before they start.

Consequences for breaking rules must also be delivered in a consistent manner. Nothing will break the spirit and morale of a team quite like applying rules differently for different team members. Consistency matters.

Being firm is necessary with both yourself and your team members, but above all, being consistent is the most important aspect of disciplining yourself. Consistency in how you deal with people is the hallmark of a great leader.

Pat’s mindset was, “Discipline is the only sure way I know to convince people to believe in themselves.”